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The routes to intellectual authority in a prior colonial empire: continued racialised, geopolitical inequalities in the academic staff composition and employment conditions of UK universities

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ABSTRACT

Two problematics are exposed and explored within this paper which currently undermine the United Kingdom’s international commitments to address racial inequality and injustice: (1) the routes to national, regional, and international intellectual authority via the academic profession, particularly the assigned leadership position of full professor or ‘chair’; and (2) the effects of dysconscious data literacy, which is out of step with international mechanisms and agendas to combat racism and xenophobia. This is undertaken through a critical quantitative analysis of administrative data about the socio-demographic composition and employment conditions of academic staff in the devolved nations of England, Northern Ireland, Scotland, and Wales. Iniquitous employment conditions revealed how the social determinants of ‘race’, ‘sex’, ‘nationality’, and ‘religious belief impact academics’ access to employment and participation once employed; particularly in the discipline of Education. Shortcomings in categorisation and reporting of official data serve to obfuscate transparency and accountability about inequality.

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Historicising the problem of ‘race’ in Western science and of routes to intellectual authority

‘Authority’ involves influence and power, which in some contexts evokes negative associations of bias or repression.¹ However, the power to author, authorise, and act as an authority is central to the flow and impact of thought, and the dynamics of relations between individuals, groups, and institutions within society and globally. Intellectual authority in its purest form is about establishing grounds to embark on, and have influence through, truth claims; it is also a necessary condition for having a hearing from those in positions to grant justice (Blackmore 2022). Although not exclusive, a traditional route to intellectual authority is through the university. Universities (in)

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form, legitimate, and position persons epistemically, socially, culturally, politically and institutionally to play authoritative roles within their disciplines, institutions, and, beyond, within societies.² This is the route for which universities extend their institutional authority³ through bureaucratically awarded credentialisation (including degrees and the PhD) and affiliation through access to employment, with increasing professional authority up the academic ladder (complete with titles) to the assigned leadership position of full professor or ‘chair’. In this paper, we contribute to scholarship about the ways in which the routes to authority in Western society and in the sciences continue to be plagued by injustice, including racism and geopolitics.

To de-idealise the roots of international intellectual authority, we briefly highlight specific markers in time. Historian Brattain (2007) revealed how 75 years ago, following consciousness that Western science enabled the atrocities of two world wars and the Holocaust, an international group of scholars drafted UNESCO’s first *Statement on Race* (1950) as ‘more “social myth” than “biological fact”’. Power-plays between those authoring the declaration led to concessions and eventually capitulation. What was eventually published (UNESCO 1951) was a less radical repudiation of racist thinking which returned ‘to a biological definition of race, and, significantly, also affirmed older scientific traditions (and languages) by noting differences between “non-literate” and “more civilized” people’ (Brattain 2007, 1387). This reaffirmation of the *coloniality* of Western science was at the dawn of the decolonialisation of Africa, and contrary to the later international recognition that there should be an end to ‘all practices of segregation and discrimination associated therewith’ (United Nations 1960). Such dynamics demonstrate how progress on greater social justice is undermined by inequalities in the positions of power of those who author authoritative texts. Thus, one of the criteria for addressing the injustices of science as ‘social knowledge’ is ‘equality of intellectual authority’ (Longino 2020).

In the early 1990s, the Black scholar Cornel West (1993, 59) wrote insightfully about becoming an intellectual in the United States of America: ‘The way in which one becomes a black intellectual is highly problematic. This is so because *the traditional roads others travel to become intellectuals* in American society have only recently been opened to black people remain quite difficult. The main avenues are the academy or the literate subcultures’ (emphasis added). Thus, ‘intellectual authorities’ are described as ‘thought leaders’ by those tracing genealogical trajectories beyond academia (such as in Alridge et al. 2021, Newman 2023). Such processes of reclaiming individual figures of intellectual authority (such as in Banks 1996) are enriched by looking at ‘the patterns, changes and complexities of black thought expressed in different contexts by people that did not fit a definition of the black intellectual as an elite’ (Sesay 2015, n.p.) so as to ‘historicize the category of black intellectuals by examining the processes through which blacks have been *granted* and have *seized* intellectual authority’ (Sesay 2015, n.p., emphasis added). While exploring such agential seizing within Black British intellectual traditions (Warmington 2014), Warmington (2012, 5) articulated that ‘the field of Education, both as a site of intellectual production and as the site of political struggle for black communities, is one of the significant fields in which black British intellectual positions have been defined and differentiated’. ‘Academic authority’ is the term used by Kazembe, et al. (2023) to distinguish

broader possibilities of intellectual authority from the racial politics between academic citizens *within* white-dominated institutions. In addition to such social, ontological, and epistemic injustices, limits on the conditions for transformative ‘intellectual leadership’ of full professors or ‘chairs’ are also shaped by managerialism and neoliberalism (MacFarlane 2012). Thus, we recognise while assigned ‘academic leadership’ (Ruan 2021) positions of full professor or ‘chair’ may be formal bureaucratic positions at the apex of the institutionalised hierarchy of ‘academic authority’ (Kazembe et al. 2023), they cannot be assumed to be always already aligned with the practice of intellectual authority. This paper specifically considers the pipelines of traditional routes afforded by the university.

Towards the end of the 20th Century, the UN Commission of Human Rights (1997) passed resolution 1997/74 to emphasize the importance of ‘measures to combat contemporary forms of racism, racial discrimination, xenophobia and related intolerance’. Concerns were raised that very year about the lack of ‘data about ethnicity and staffing’ of those in the academic profession in one of the prior empires, the United Kingdom (UK) (Heward, Taylor, and Vickers 1997, 206). A few years later, the Durban Declaration and Programme of Action (2001) was agreed upon at the World Conference against Racism in post-apartheid South Africa. Paragraph 92’s guidance was that,

States should collect, compile, analyse, disseminate and publish reliable statistical data at the national and local levels, and take all other related measures necessary to assess regularly the situation of people of African descent who are victims of racism, racial discrimination, xenophobia and related intolerance. Such statistical data should be disaggregated in accordance with national legislation, upholding the right to privacy and the principle of self-identification. The information should be collected to monitor the situation of people of African descent, assess progress made, increase their visibility, and identify social gaps. It should also be used to assess and guide the formulation of policies and actions to prevent, combat and eradicate racism, racial discrimination, xenophobia and related intolerance.

Follow-up mechanisms and processes since have included the *Agenda Towards Transformative Change for Racial Justice and Equality*; the *2030 Sustainable Development Agenda* as ‘a renewed opportunity to place racial equality and justice as the centrepiece of international, regional, and national agenda’ (United Nations 2021, n. p.); and the initiative ending in the year of publication of this text, *The International Decade for People of African Descent (UNIDPAD)*. The UK Government (2024) has espoused commitments to these initiatives, including most recently to the second decade, as have many of its public universities.

To raise questions about the relation of these commitments to the routes to intellectual authority within its borders, in this paper we contribute a critical quantitative analysis of the administrative dataset held by the Higher Education Statistics Agency (HESA) on the staff composition and employment conditions of academic staff at all UK public universities, with particular consideration of the discipline of Education. Before we unpack that analysis, we briefly contextualise the issue through counter-discourses offered by critical scholarship of the UK academy.

Contextualising the problem of ‘race’ in the UK and its institutionalised routes to intellectual authority

The British Empire weaponised educational institutions and science to further the purposes of colonialism and enslavement, and continued to legislate the racial segregation of access to citizenry rights within its current borders into the 1980s (Patel 2022). Despite that history, and the contemporary claims of commitments to the mechanisms and programmes outlined in the section above, there has been a consistent pattern of evasion and delay in relation to legislation, accountability, and the public social imaginary when it comes to racism and xenophobia within the UK. Institutional racism was introduced into England’s public lexicon as late as 1999 (Macpherson 1999) and even later in Northern Ireland (McVeigh and Duchan 2005), both due to considerable pressure of civil society bodies in the face of harms and injustices. Social regulation is enacted through national equality legislation where public institutions are ascribed duties to protect individuals, with markers of what are called ‘protected characteristics’, from discrimination or harm. These include ‘race’ and ‘national origin’. The devolution of Great Britain and Northern Ireland has allowed for the dispersal of legislative powers for some decision-making at local levels in England, Scotland, Northern Ireland, and Wales, with others centralised in Westminster. Thus differing interventions and targets have arisen to address inequality since 1998–99 (Shattock and Horvath 2020), with gaps in legislative provision to protect against racism and xenophobia most notable in Northern Ireland (Gilligan 2019). Despite so-called equality policy, attention to issues within universities has lagged, requiring insider-scholars to raise concerns about the continued ‘contests over power, intellectual authority and ethnic identity’ and ‘cultural containment through hegemonic practices’ in their analysis of racism within UK institutions (Phillips 2021, 421).

In the past decade, scholars have noted a lessening of the salience of ‘race’ in policy in education (Gillborn et al. 2016) and higher education (Pilkington 2018). Institutional racism was recently excluded in England’s 2017 Race Disparity Audit (Smith 2023) and denied in the UK-wide 2020 Commission on Race and Ethnic Disparities (Gopal and Rao 2021). Parallel has been the state’s implementation of increasingly restrictive conditions for migration, with an explicitly ‘hostile environment’ of immigration policy (Griffiths and Yeo 2021; Murray and Gray 2023), and retraction from the European Union (EU, in what is termed colloquially ‘Brexit’). This has been accompanied by the social policing of ‘British values’ through securitisation, religious, and racial profiling (Danvers 2021), with public discourse and legislation evoking racialised limits to the rights of citizenship, which most publicly impacted those of Caribbean descent (known as ‘the Windrush Generation’). The casting of equality as a political imposition on academic freedom has become increasingly prevalent in this period (as in other Western contexts, see Douglass 2023). Politicians’ rhetoric and pressure on bodies within the higher education ecology, indicate that racial equality is perceived as a political threat to the ontological security of those in power. A recent public demonstration of this, waged on social media, was aimed at an academic member of an external advisory group for equality, diversity, and inclusion (EDI) of the UK’s Research and

Innovation funding body (UKRI), in response to their public engagement about Israel's military attacks on Gaza in 2023 (Coe 2023).

Critical scholarship's counter-discourses of the UK university

In this section, we draw on critical scholars concerned that the ideograph through which UK 'universities typically see themselves', despite evidence to the contrary, continues to maintain the untruth that 'existing policies ensure fairness' (Pilkington 2020, 29). Social inequality is further depoliticised by the current milieu's neoliberal discourses of individualism and responsibilisation, which inform both policy craft and institutions' performative statements of commitment to accommodate 'diversity'.

Heward et al. (1995) emphasized the importance of charting and studying the 'routes to power in the academic profession' for racialised minorities almost thirty years ago. They argued that 'explicating the processes by which they are eliminated from the profession remains a most important and intractable problem' (Heward et al. 1995, 149). Scholarship engaging with this problem over the past decade have been vast. For instance, the pipeline from the doctorate has been studied, revealing broken access to academic employment for Black scholars in England (Alexander and Arday 2015). There has also been scrutiny of sectoral initiatives to address institutional inequality for women, such as Athena SWAN (Scientific Women's Academic Network) from 2005, and for racialised minorities, such as the Race Equality Charter from 2014. The lack of employment gains, for those racialised as minorities, have been exposed (Baltaru 2023; Bhopal and Pitkin 2020). Moreover, the ill-effects of bullying, discrimination, racism, and exclusion on those positioned at the intersections of structures of race, sex (Gabriel and Anne Tate 2017), religion (Akel 2021) and ableism (Lewis and Arday 2023) on mental health have become a growing concern (Arday 2018, 2022). Insider insights have been so dire that one report was titled, 'How can we make not break black and minority ethnic leaders in higher education?' (Singh and Kwhali 2015). Thus, the assigned academic leadership and its relation to the intersections of race, gender (Rollock 2019, 2021) and migration (Sang, Al-Dajani, and Özbilgin 2013) have been a concern studied.

Scholarly interest in the politics of internal and international academic im/mobility has grown more generally (Tzanakou and Henderson 2021), particularly with conscientisation following 'Brexit'-related constraints (Courtois and Sautier 2022) and the deputisation of fellow academic citizens as visa police (Griffiths and Yeo 2021). Editors of a special issue on international academic mobility for the Journal of Ethnic and Migration Studies called for extending the scope of scholarship to recognise connections between inequalities in opportunity and outcome (Bilecen and Van Mol 2017), to which this paper responds. While 'national origin' is a 'protected characteristic' of equality legislation, it remains conspicuously unscrutinised by the sectors' practice-based interventions (including Athena SWAN and the Race Equality Charter) and de-prioritised in UKRI's (2021, 2024) analyses of research funding award gaps.

In the next section, we discuss the methodological challenges faced to realise the intention to explore the routes to intellectual authority provided via the university.

Methodological notes

There is particular concern about truth claims being dis/allowed through the ways public institutions monitor, report, construct categories and statistics (Crawford 2019). It was precisely because of the rhetorical force of such claims that we decided to critically respond to a call by a leading educational learned society, the British Educational Research Association, to study the ‘state of the discipline’ of Education in the UK. A systematic scoping review of UK educational research that they had funded found only one study about academics of colour (termed ‘ethnic minorities’ therein); none about disability or those who identify as LGBTQ+; and few about female staff (Stentiford et al. 2021). The funding awarded enabled our access to purchase and explore HESA’s administrative data held on the 24,530 academic staff employed at UK universities, which we were cognisant would be received as an authoritative and ‘unbiased’ source. However, as we discuss here (and in relation to our broader, descriptive statistical analysis of the data on ‘sex’, ‘race’, ‘age’, ‘nationality’, ‘religious belief’, and ‘dis/ability’ in the study report, see Belluigi et al. 2023), the dataset came with considerable limitations, including restrictions placed on our representations.

Our navigation of the dysconscious data literacy inherent to the purchased datasets is structured in dialogue with guiding principles of Gillborn, Warmington, and Demack’s (2018) ‘Quantitative Critical Race Theory’ (QuantCrit). Dysconsciousness points to ways of thinking that are distorted by frames of reference and taken-for-granted norms. The term has been used to comprehend the maintenance and reproduction of immoral framings of racism within education (King 1991), and racism and xenophobiaism in university settings (Belluigi 2024).

Recognising that the centrality of racism is difficult to measure and is often obscured, is the first QuantCrit principle. Critical data justice is posited as a systemic way to address wilful dysconsciousness in paragraph 92 of the Durban Programme of Action and the UNIDPAD, as discussed in the introduction. However, no such literacy was evident in the curation of the purchased datasets, despite the careful crafting of our questions, considerable back-and-forth communications, and the cost of purchasing additional datasets to improve validity (see Table 1).

Table 1. Categorisation of UK staff in datasets curated by HESA related to terms used in this paper (also represented in Belluigi et al. 2024, 12).

First HESA data set	Second HESA data set	Terms used in this paper
‘ethnicity’		‘Race’ or ‘racialised ethnicities’
‘white’, ‘BAME’, other, unknown		Recorded as ‘white’
‘white’	(no further differentiated data provided)	Recorded as ‘racialised ethnic minority’
		Recorded as ‘white’
‘Black’	Black/Black British Caribbean	Recorded as ‘black’ Caribbean/descent
	Black/Black African	Recorded as ‘black’ African/descent
	Other Black background	Recorded as ‘other black background’
‘Asian’	Asian/Asian British Indian Asian/Asian British Pakistani	Recorded as Indian/descent
	Asian/Asian British Bangladeshi	Recorded as Pakistani/descent
	Chinese	Recorded as Bangladeshi/descent
	Other Asian background	Recorded as Chinese/descent
		Recorded as ‘other Asian background’
‘mixed’	Mixed	Recorded as ‘mixed’
‘other’		Recorded as ‘other’
‘unknown’		Represented in percentages, proportions based on ‘known’ reporting

The cautions of the authors of QuantCrit were helpful, about interrogating how numbers are constructed to reflect and/or protect white-dominated institutions. Our reporting thus extends beyond *access* to employment, to *participation* once employed. These are represented, respectively, as percentages, to provide perspective on minoritisation and exclusions at play intercategory; followed by proportions, to compare and contrast the positioning of social groupings intracategory once employed. Foucault's (1970, 29) emphasis on the ethico-political nature of such analysis reminded us that '[A] though arithmetic may well be the concern of democratic cities, because it teaches about the relations of equality, geometry alone must be taught in oligarchies, since it demonstrates the proportions within inequality'.

In addition, we pointed out incomplete gaps and uncertainties about such numbers to keep 'the shortcomings of the archive before our eyes' because 'gaps are crucial elements of the historical record' (Coen 2014, 429) of science. In climates of 'inevitable and routine data collection', 'blank spots that exist in spaces that are otherwise data-saturated' (Onuoha 2018, n.p.) can be insightful for what they reveal and obscure about power in archiving. The firmly legislated monitoring of 'sex' ('male', 'female', and from 2017 'other') produced no gaps, in contrast to the missing data of the other 'protected characteristics' under the UK equality acts which we explored, including 'race', multiple nationalities, religious belief and disability. This produced inconsistencies in what can be known. Data injustice is writ large in the presence of missing data which 'typically correlates with issues affecting those who are most vulnerable in that context' (Onuoha 2018, n.p.). This led us to write about the implications for dominant narratives about equality for UK-based academic 'women' (Belluigi, Arday and O'Keeffe 2024); with hedging in our findings and clarity in the shifts in our wording below because the data limited us to explorations of 'sex' and not 'gender'. We also could not explore intersections with class, because despite such stratification being a feature of British society and its universities, such data is not reported to HESA. A myriad of advantages and interests are served by the nonexistence of such data, from the institutional context and the social reception of identities affecting reporting (Fox and Gasper 2020), through to missing data being indicative of refusal or protective measures from those situationally disadvantaged (Onuoha 2018, n.p.); symptomatic of distrust (Blockmans 2015) or fatigue at the inefficacy of change (Read, Miles, and Merchant 2020).

The second CritQuant principle foregrounds problematics with categorisation. Criticality is required to challenge the normalisation and mobilisation of contested categories, such as 'race', because of their role in creating and also disguising inequality. Black feminist scholarship, including that in the USA (Crenshaw 1989) and the UK (Tate and Bagguley 2017), has contributed conceptual and analytical tools to address the demarcation of such group boundaries, by centring intersecting systems of oppression. A fundamental problem was how the language of 'ethnicity', utilised in modern UK bureaucratic governance, obscured racialisation and groups of heterogeneous peoples in ways misrepresentative of (distinct and shared) histories and ethnicities. Such categories have altered over time, and are inconsistently applied in the four devolved regions. Aspinall (2020) highlights contrasting purposes in the changes, including political advocacy for more heterogeneities (such as the distinction between 'Black' and 'Asian' from 'minority ethnic' within the composite acronym 'BAME' for 'black, Asian, and minority ethnic'), which have not always

been understood by UK scientists (see for instance Khunti et al. 2020). Within the ‘ethnicity’ dataset we were provided, HESA initially distinguished ‘white’ only from ‘other-than-white’, later providing differentiations after more requests (Table 1). Even these differentiations are somewhat unhelpful – such as the blanket category ‘mixed’ which groups together all people whose racial identifications include more than one of the existing ‘ethnic’ categories. Njaka (2022) has raised concerns about the dearth of UK research on those who fall within this category. In this paper, we utilised ‘racialised minorities’ to recognise that the ideological fiction and pseudoscience of ‘race’ has had material impacts on those from, and descendant from, the Majority World living in the Minority World. This was in part informed by Selvarajah’s et al. (2020) recommendation of ‘minoritised’ as a universal term, drawn from structural analyses of separation and segregation in power in the UK, USA, and South Africa. Related to this was our avoidance of the un-representation of extreme minoritisation, particularly at the level of full professor, when complying with HESA’s limitations of representing rounded numbers. Albeit awkward, we choose mathematical signs (><) to explicitly indicate that the act of rounding to the nearest 0.5% had occurred.

HESA directs institutions to record one ‘primary nationality’ per staff member, prioritised in order of citizenship of the UK, EU, and ‘non-UK/EU’, in compliance with UK and EU Border employment legislation. Unrecorded are nationality changes, the hidden dimensions of national background, self-identification, and associations projected by colleagues, in an academic labour market affected by epistemic in/exclusion based on the country where the doctorate was awarded (Pustelnikovaite and Chillas 2022). To explore geopolitical inequality, we utilised country income categories of the World Bank⁴ (Table 2). Terms Minority/Majority World explicitly assert the representational injustice at play, when the dominance of a minority of the world’s peoples ‘represent a tiny fraction of humankind’ yet claims to be the epitome of democracy (Alam 2008).

Table 2. Grouping of data about the ‘primary nationality’ of academic staff.

‘Primary nationality’ categorised by UK legislative framing	Our coding by Country Income Category of the World Bank (2020)	Assumed relation	Wording utilised in the report
UK	High Income	high socio-economic resources international decision- making power represent a minority of the world’s populations and interests	‘High Income’ ‘the Minority World’ ‘Global North’
EU non-UK/EU	Upper Middle Income Lower Middle Income Low Income	socio-economic resources are unequally distributed under-represented in international decision- making for those who comprise the majority of the worlds’ population	‘LMICs’ ‘the Majority World’ ‘Global South’

To deepen interpretations of the quantitative through the qualitative, the fourth QuantCrit principle, we engaged critical scholarship (cited herein and in an open access bibliography⁵), but hope the study further catalyses insider insights of the routes to intellectual authority in the discipline of Education in particular. As persons within that discipline, we were informed by our prior qualitative research on inequalities in higher/education, in addition to our differing loci of enunciation as three academic citizens with differing racialisations, national and geopolitical origins, abilities, and genders. We drew on these as sensitisation devices: in the process of inter- and intracategorical questions posed; in negotiating the power structures that shaped the production of the project; and in publishing the imperfections of our negotiations.

We committed to the fifth guiding principle of CritQuant, that is trying to utilise quantitative data as anti-oppressive praxis in support of social justice, as indicated at the beginning of this section. Open-access dissemination included visualisations (inspired by DuBois’ data portraits, see Battle-Baptiste and Rusert 2018); presentations to those in assigned leadership of Education in UK universities; and scholarly Minority World communities.

Findings

We begin by foregrounding the structure of ‘race’ in the academy in 2020, with highlighted findings of inequalities in access and participation; before looking at migrant academic access and participation, and the ‘glocal’ inequalities therein.

The ‘races’ represented in the staff composition

Across UK universities, 75% of staff were recorded as ‘white’, 16.5% as racialised minorities, with 9% ‘unknown’. The discipline of Education employed a higher proportion recorded as ‘white’, at a difference of >10% (refer to the methodology for why we indicate such acts of rounding to the nearest 0.5%). Only 8% were recorded as racialised minorities, with 6.5% ‘unknown’. The missing data for those employed in the discipline of Education had gendered and contextual dimensions. For instance, the lowest percentage of ‘unknown’ reporting for ‘ethnicity’ was in Wales, which was recorded as for less female staff (just under <1%), than male staff (3%); with Scotland the highest (>6% female staff; >12% male staff). Proportions within the differentiated data of racialised minorities are tabulated below (Table 3).

Table 3. Differentiated proportions of the ‘ethnicity’ of academic staff.

	Education	UK sector
unknown	6.5%	9%
Racialised minoritises (‘BAME’)	8%	16.5%
Bangladeshi/descent	2.0%	2.0%
Indian/descent	14.0%	18.0%
Pakistani/descent	6.0%	5.0%
Other Asian background	11.0%	13.0%
Chinese/descent	11.5%	22%
African/descent	10.0%	9.0%
Caribbean/descent	8.0%	3.0%
other black background	2.0%	1.0%
mixed	21.0%	14.0%
other	15.0%	13.5%
white	69.0%	61.0%

Findings reported, from this point on, are based on the *known* data reported in 2020, unless explicitly specified. Differences in the devolved nations' staff composition, as visualised in Figure 1, showed the highest proportion of racialised minorities in England. Within each devolved nation, the discipline of Education was exposed as having a far lower proportion of racially minoritised staff. Representation was lower than Census population records, wherein racialised minorities were represented in 18% of England; 3.4% Northern Ireland; 4.5% Scotland; 5.2% Wales.

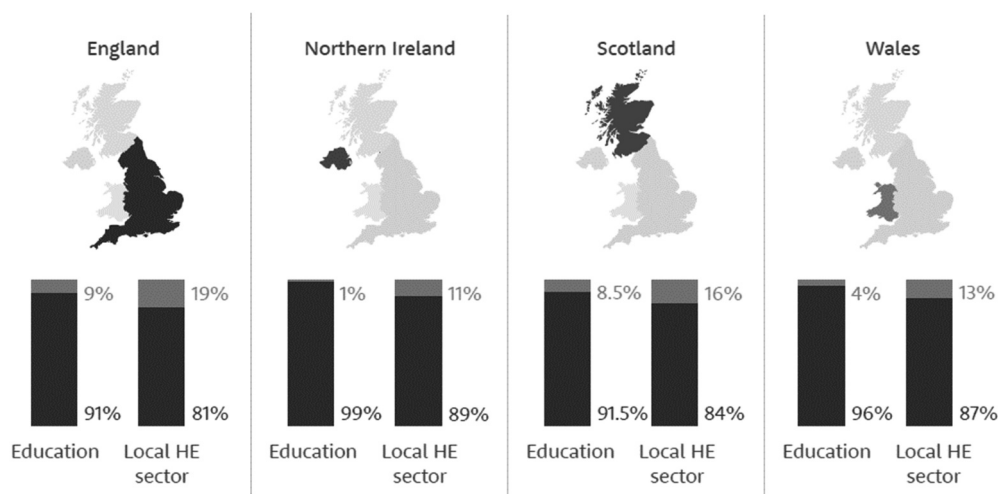


Figure 1. Visualisation of the academic staff composition of those employed in the UK's devolved nations, showing combined racialised minorities (lighter grey) and 'white' grouping (darker grey) for staff in the local higher education sector, and those in the discipline of Education (from Belluigi, Arday and O'Keeffe 2023, 44).

In an attempt to identify changes over the period studied, data about new recruits, promotions and attrition was explored within the period 2015 to 2020. We found Education had a far lower growth rate in the employment of those recorded as 'black' (a rate of 13.5%) than UK HE (a rate of >53%), and those recorded as 'mixed' (a rate of 26.5% in Education; 46.5% in UK HE). The proportion of racialised minorities promoted increased from >7% to >10%; however, the lowest proportion thereof was those recorded as 'black' (<2%).

General reporting of 'sex' in UK universities showed lower proportions of female staff (47%) than male staff (53%). Data is missing when sex is analysed by 'race'; however, from the known data about racially minoritised staff (<19%), there was a higher proportion of males (58.5%) than females (41.5%). This differed from the composition of those recorded as 'white' (males <54%; females <46%). England not only had the highest percentage of staff recorded as racialised ethnic minorities (>19%) but also the highest proportion of female academics in that group (>42%). The lowest proportion of females within groupings of racialised minorities was in Northern Ireland (>29%), while the proportion of female academics recorded as 'white' (>46%) were consistent with the other devolved nations. The discipline of Education in Wales

Table 4. Differentiated proportions of 'ethnicities' by sex.

	Education	UK sector
Bangladeshi/descent	>0%	>0%
Female	60.0%	34.0%
Male	40.5%	66.0%
Indian/descent	1.0%	3.0%
Female	74.0%	43.0%
Male	26.0%	57.0%
Pakistani/descent	0.5%	1%
Female	70.5%	37.0%
Male	29.5%	63.0%
other Asian background	1.0%	2.0%
Female	64.0%	44.5%
Male	36.0%	55.5%
Chinese/descent	1.0%	4.0%
Female	80.0%	42.0%
Male	20.0%	58.0%
Black African/descent	1.0%	2.0%
Female	45.0%	34.0%
Male	55.0%	66.0%
Black Caribbean/descent	1.0%	0.5%
Female	83.0%	63.0%
Male	17.0%	37.0%
Other black background	>0%	>0%
Female	67.0%	44.0%
Male	33.0%	56.0%
mixed	2.0%	2.5%
Female	70.0%	51.5%
Male	30.0%	48.5%
other	1.0%	2.0%
Female	64.5%	43.0%
Male	35.5%	57.0%
'white'	91.0%	82.0%
Female	69.0%	48.0%
Male	31.0%	52.0%

had the highest proportion of female to male staff for those recorded as racialised minorities (<75%: >25%) and for those recorded as 'white' (>71%: >29%). However, differences emerged in the differentiated data of racialised minorities (Table 4) (though readers should interpret this with caution, as the actual numbers of academics were small with high proportions 'unknown'). The patterns of more males to females were similar across most categories in UK universities in general. This differed in Education, with more females to males - however, differentiated data revealed differences, such as the proportion of males of black African/descent being higher than females.

Far higher proportions of racialised minorities held Buddhist, Hindu, Jewish, Muslim, Sikh, and 'Spiritual and other' religious beliefs (see Table 5). The interplay between race, gender, and Islamophobia has been reported in qualitative studies of UK universities

Table 5. Differentiated proportions of 'ethnic' groups by religious belief.

	Education	UK sector
Racialised minorities ('BAME')	10.0%	26.0%
Christian	44.0%	32.5%
'Spiritual and other' and Buddhist, Hindu, Jewish, Muslim, Sikh	56.0%	68.0%
'white'	90.0%	74.0%
Christian	83.0%	81.0%
'Spiritual and other' and Buddhist, Hindu, Jewish, Muslim, Sikh	17.0%	19.0%

(Ramadan 2022). We found that staff recorded as ‘white’ were overwhelmingly Christian. The higher composition of Christians in Education generally supports calls for research on the conditions for pluralistic religious education (Nelson and Yang 2023) in a discipline overwhelmingly composed of staff with one religious belief.

Education had a higher proportion of racialised minorities with a known disability (5.5%) than that recorded across UK universities (<3%), although the HESA data curation disallowed further exploration. In Education, 7% of racially minoritised staff provided ill-health as a reason for attrition.

Detailed analysis about nationality appears below; however, it is relevant to note the different portions when access to employment is considered by ‘race’ and nationality (Table 6). Viewed positively, racialised minorities play a significant role in contributing global representation to the staffing of both UK universities and the discipline of Education. However, this also indicates that most UK-based racialised minorities would find conditions impacted by systemic and interactional responses to migration from the Majority World.

In the section following, we delve into differences observed when analysing ‘race’ in terms of the employment conditions and positioning of staff.

Table 6. Staff proportions grouped by ‘race’ and primary nationality

	Education	UK sector
Racialised minorities (‘BAME’)	9.0%	18.0%
EU	5.0%	5.0%
Non-EU	30.0%	52.0%
UK	65.0%	43.0%
‘white’	91.0%	82.0%
EU	7.0%	20.0%
Non-EU	2.5%	6.0%

‘Race’ and employment conditions

UK universities removed the security of tenure in 1988, through the Education Reform Act of 1988, and have stratified the route up many rungs of the academic ladder to the assigned leadership of full professor. We found a higher proportion of racialised minorities than those ‘white’ in fixed-term contracts (see Table 7) which are generally more precarious. The discipline of Education offered more secure employment generally, and for racially minority academics, than across UK universities. There was also a more substantial rate of growth for the few Education staff recorded as racialised minorities on permanent contracts (<45%) than the rate in the UK HE sector (<37%).

Table 7. Staff grouped ‘race’ showing proportions on fixed or open-ended contracts

	Education	UK sector
Racialised minorities (‘BAME’)	9.5%	19.0%
Fixed-term	17.0%	37.5%
Open-ended/Permanent	83.0%	62.5%
‘white’	90.5%	81.0%
Fixed-term	14.5%	24.0%
Open-ended/Permanent	85.5%	76.0%

The contract of ‘teaching and research’ is most conducive for holistic academic practice, progression, and being awarded research funding, and thus traditionally enabling of intellectual authority. There was a decrease in this employment function in the 5-year period studied, and growth in ‘teaching only’ contacts, in the sector. However, for racialised ethnic minorities in Education the decrease was by 14% compared to 7% of their counterparts. In the sector, as indicated in the [Table 8](#), racialised minorities were employed in higher proportions in ‘research only’ contacts than their counterparts.

Table 8. Staff by ‘race’ showing proportions by employment function.

	Education	UK sector
Racialised minorities (‘BAME’)	9.5%	19.0%
Academic contract that is both teaching and research	57.0%	45.0%
Academic contract that is neither teaching nor research	1.0%	0.0%
Academic contract that is research only	12.0%	38.0%
Academic contract that is teaching only	30.0%	16.5%
‘white’	90.5%	81.3%
Academic contract that is both teaching and research	60.0%	54.0%
Academic contract that is neither teaching nor research	0.5%	1.0%
Academic contract that is research only	6.0%	23.0%
Academic contract that is teaching only	34.0%	22.0%

[Table 9](#) outlines the relevant differentiated data. Over-concentration of non-UK academics within research-only posts which are ‘less valued and are difficult to fill by UK academics’ is a division of labour noted in elite academic institutions (Khattab and Fenton 2016).

Moreover, we observed a reduction in Education’s proportion of ‘teaching and research’ contracts awarded to racialised minorities (from 72% in 2015 to >57% in 2020), at both at junior levels (from >39% to >24%) and senior levels (from >83% to 72%). Thus, increases for such staff were in ‘teaching only’ contracts at junior level (15.5% in 2015 to >30% in 2020). [Table 10](#) reveals a higher proportion of racialised minorities in junior positions than senior, when compared to their counterparts. Such proportions showed more inequality in Education.

[Table 11](#) presents participation at the level of assigned leadership of full professor and senior management, with a narrowing of progression for racialised minorities in UK universities. The proportion of Education staff recorded as racialised minorities who had progressed to full professors in 2020 increased to >6% over the period studied; however, it should be remembered that the overall percentage was at a lower proportion than the sector.

[Table 12](#) shows that the highest proportion of racialised minorities who were full professors in UK universities were recorded as ‘Asian’ (7%), and then ‘mixed’ (<1.5%). The >0.5% included within the ‘Black’ grouping were mostly those of African/descent. Education had no full professors recorded of Bangladeshi/descent; no female full professors in Education recorded as black African/descent nor ‘other black background’; and no male full professors recorded as black Caribbean/descent nor other black background.

Systemic problematics with promotion at such levels have been reported (Miller 2016), where constructions of leadership are undergirded by racism and patriarchy

Table 9. Differentiated data about racialised minorities by academic employment function.

	Education	UK sector
Bangladeshi/descent	2.0%	2.0%
Academic contract that is both teaching and research	30.0%	44.0%
Academic contract that is research only	16.0%	36.0%
Academic contract that is teaching only	53.0%	20.0%
Indian/descent	15.0%	18.0%
Academic contract that is both teaching and research	62.0%	43.0%
Academic contract that is research only	12.0%	42.5%
Academic contract that is teaching only	26.5%	14.5%
Pakistani/descent	6.0%	5.0%
Academic contract that is both teaching and research	65.5%	47.0%
Academic contract that is research only	5.0%	31.0%
Academic contract that is teaching only	29.0%	22.0%
Chinese/descent	12.0%	23.0%
Academic contract that is both teaching and research	57.0%	45.0%
Academic contract that is research only	23.0%	46.0%
Academic contract that is teaching only	20.0%	9.0%
other Asian background	10.0%	13.0%
Academic contract that is both teaching and research	62.0%	46.0%
Academic contract that is research only	12.0%	39.0%
Academic contract that is teaching only	26.0%	15.0%
Black African/descent	10.0%	9.0%
Academic contract that is both teaching and research	58.0%	47.0%
Academic contract that is research only	11.0%	27.0%
Academic contract that is teaching only	31.0%	26.0%
Black Caribbean/descent	7.0%	2.0%
Academic contract that is both teaching and research	51.0%	50.0%
Academic contract that is research only	5.0%	13.0%
Academic contract that is teaching only	44.0%	36.0%
other Black background	2.0%	1.0%
Academic contract that is both teaching and research	64.0%	45.0%
Academic contract that is research only	0.0%	30.5%
Academic contract that is teaching only	36.5%	24.0%
mixed	21.0%	13.0%
Academic contract that is both teaching and research	59.0%	46.0%
Academic contract that is research only	10.0%	34.0%
Academic contract that is teaching only	30.0%	19.0%
other	15.0%	13.0%
Academic contract that is both teaching and research	51.0%	46.0%
Academic contract that is research only	17.0%	35.5%
Academic contract that is teaching only	32.0%	18.0%

Table 10. ‘Race’ of staff by proportions at junior and senior levels

	Education	UK sector
Racialised minorities (‘BAME’)	10.0%	19.0%
Junior academic	35.0%	52.0%
Senior academic	65.0%	48.0%
‘white’	90.0%	81.0%
Junior academic	26.0%	37.0%
Senior academic	74.0%	63.0%

(Arday 2018; Rollock 2021; Singh and Kwhali 2015). In Education, we observed no promotions of ‘black staff’ to full professor position in the period studied. Zelzer (2023) analysed progression rates of UK full professors beyond the timeline of this study, reporting that by 2022 there was only a rounded total (to the nearest 5) of 170

Table 11. ‘Race’ by proportions of contract levels, differentiating full professor and senior management

	Education	UK sector
Racialised minorities ('BAME')	9.5%	19.0%
Other contract level	91.0%	92.0%
Full professor	6.0%	7.0%
Senior management	2.0%	1.5%
'white'	90.5%	81.0%
Other contract level	89.0%	84.0%
Full professor	7.0%	12.0%
Senior management	5.0%	4.0%

Table 12. Known differentiated data on the ‘race’ of full professors.

	Education	UK sector
Racialised minorities ('BAME')	>8%	<11%
Bangladeshi/descent	0%	>0%
Indian/descent	>1%	2.5%
Pakistani/descent	>0%	>0%
Other Asian background	>0%	>1%
Chinese	<2%	<3%
African/descent	>0%	0.5%
Caribbean/descent	>0%	>0%
Other black background	0%	>0%
Mixed	<2%	>1%
Other	2%	<2%
'white'	<92%	>89%

black full professors in the UK, of which 45 were female. Despite the public discourse about the small proportions of racialised minorities full professors in the UK university sector, institutional statements during attention to the matter of BlackLivesMatter, and the practice-based interventions noted in the introduction to this paper, we found an increase (from 37.5% in 2016 to 73.5% in 2020) in those ‘white’ recruited to that level within Education.

When it came to reasons provided for attrition, the large proportions of missing data (21% in UK HE; <36% in Education) necessitate that figures are not adjusted in representation on that issue to avoid misrepresentation. Across UK universities, racialised minorities who reported on attrition, cited end of contract (>34%), resignation (<33%), and ‘other (includes dismissal and ill-health)’ (4%). However, >17% did not provide a reason. A slightly lower proportion of those ‘white’ provided resignation (<29%) as the reason for leaving, and >25% their fixed-term contract ending. Education’s racialised minorities cited resignation (<28%), end of fixed-term contract (22%), and ‘other (including dismissal or ill health)’ (>7). Of those recorded as ‘white’, the highest proportion was the fixed-term contract ending (>20%), resignation (19%), retirement (<8%), continued employment (6.5%), voluntary redundancy (5%), other redundancy (<4%), and ‘other (dismissals and ill health)’ (3%). Prior studies have argued that the symptoms of the adverse effects of racism, compounded by neoliberal pressures in the UK, are staff mental ill-health (Arday 2022; Morrish and Priaux 2020) and attrition (Bhopal, Brown, and Jackson 2018).

Nationalities represented in the staff composition

This section expands the analysis of racial inequalities to nationality, migration, and global inequalities. As tabulated below, the ‘primary nationalities’ of UK-based academics in 2020 were predominantly from the UK, with Education having a 20% higher proportion.

Rates of growth were noted in the employment of those recorded as non-EU/UK compared (>29% UK HE sector, >56% Education). To give a sense of this, in 2016 the majority of new recruits in Education held UK primary nationality (>79%) and the lowest proportion was reported as non-EU/UK primary nationality (>6%). In 2020, these figures increased to >85% for those with UK primary nationality and to >8% for those recorded with non-EU/UK primary nationality, with lower proportions of starters holding EU primary nationalities. However, employment conditions for non-UK/EU academics had the lowest proportion promoted in Education in 2020 (9%), with attrition increasing from >2% in 2016 to <5%. Scholarly interest in academics from outside the EU Economic Area has long-drawn attention to the inter-relationships between highly skilled academic mobility, globalisation, and labour immigration policy, with juxtapositions highlighted between the perceived ease of movement, and restrictions of border and immigration controls (Mavroudi and Warren 2013). Marini (2018) inferred that the decrease of EU nationals in HESA data was due to ‘Brexodus’ of younger academic staff. However, British naturalisation applications by EU citizens increased after the 2016 EU referendum, for reasons such as perceived loss of status and threat from Brexit (Godin and Sigona 2022). Applications for UK naturalisation from those with non-EU/UK nationalities were also higher in that period.⁶

Table 13 presents proportions when nationality is considered by ‘race’. In both UK universities and the discipline of Education, the highest proportions of racialised minorities were those holding non-UK-EU nationalities. The proportions were significantly lower in Education, because of the over-representation of those ‘white’.

While we were required to report percentages, HESA’s public data tableaus give a more tangible sense of the actual numbers (rounded to 5). For instance, of the 151,745 academics with UK primary nationality in 2020, only 2480 (1.63%) were ‘black’, of which 1510 were recorded as African/descent (650 people in ‘teaching and research’ contracts); 810 Caribbean/descent (335 in ‘teaching and research’);

Table 13. Primary nationality by ‘race’.

	Education	UK sector
EU	7%	17%
Racialised minority (‘BAME’) ‘white’	6.0% 94%	5% 95%
Non-UK/EU	5%	14%
Racialised minority (‘BAME’) ‘white’	53% 47%	67% 33%
UK	81%	69%
Racialised minority (‘BAME’) ‘white’	6% 94%	11% 89%

and 160 'other black background' (70 in 'teaching and research'). 2045 of the 31 785 staff who held non-EU/UK primary nationality were 'black'. This raises concerns about the under-representation of UK's racially minoritised citizens within UK universities. The exploitation of perverse incentives of equality reporting, which omits the intersection of primary nationality, obscures such under-representation and poses threats to race-conscious solidarities. Indeed, we found higher proportions of racialised minorities holding non-EU/UK primary nationalities in Education and the combined disciplines in each devolved nation (Table 14).

Table 14. Staff of each devolved nation's EU, non-EU/UK and UK 'primary nationalities, showing proportions by 'race'

Devolved nation	Education	UK sector
England	84.0%	84.0%
EU	6.0%	17.0%
Racialised minority ('BAME')	6.5%	5.0%
'white'	94.0%	94.8%
Non-EU	5.0%	14.0%
Racialised minority ('BAME')	55.0%	67.0%
'white'	45.0%	33.0%
UK	89.0%	69.0%
Racialised minority ('BAME')	7.0%	12.0%
'white'	93.0%	88.0%
Northern Ireland	2.0%	2.0%
EU	34.0%	33.0%
Racialised minority ('BAME')	0.0%	1.0%
'white'	100.0%	99.0%
Non-EU	2.0%	13.0%
Racialised minority ('BAME')	28.0%	65.0%
'white'	73.0%	35.0%
UK	64.0%	53.0%
Racialised minority ('BAME')	1.0%	5.0%
'white'	99.0%	95.0%
Scotland	7.0%	10.0%
EU	10.0%	20.0%
Racialised minority ('BAME')	9.0%	7.0%
'white'	91.0%	93.0%
Non-EU	9.0%	16.0%
Racialised minority ('BAME')	53.0%	66.0%
'white'	47.0%	34.0%
UK	81.0%	65.0%
Racialised minority ('BAME')	4.0%	7.0%
'white'	96.0%	93.0%
Wales	5.0%	5.0%
EU	2.0%	11.0%
Racialised minority ('BAME')	5.0%	9.0%
'white'	95.0%	91.0%
Non-EU	2.0%	10.0%
Racialised minority ('BAME')	12.5%	69.0%
'white'	87.5%	31.0%
UK	95.8%	79.0%
Racialised minority ('BAME')	3.5%	7.0%
'white'	96.5%	93.0%

We sought to ascertain the proportion of UK-based academic staff from the Majority World, where the vast majority would be racialised as 'minorities' in the UK. We found that most UK-based academic staff held primary nationality from High-Income countries, of which Education had an even higher proportion, because of its high employment of UK nationals (Table 15). Only 9% of the academics employed in UK universities and only 3% in Education held primary nationality from the Majority World, with Low-Income countries' representation so low it was rounded to zero. It bares remembering that Africa is predominantly comprised of Low-Income countries.

Access to employment from Lower-Middle-Income countries had increased to a little over >1% in Education by 2020, with was lower than the under-representation observed in the UK HE sector (>4%). Differences per devolved nation are tabulated above, in Table 16. We also found that Education had higher proportions employed at junior than senior levels from both Upper-Middle-Income countries (<9%; 4%) and Middle-Income countries (>7%; 3%).

Gender inequality was higher in senior levels in each Income Country Category,

Table 15. Staff composition by income country category of 'primary nationality'.

	Education	UK sector
High-Income	97%	90%
Upper-Middle-Income	2%	5%
Lower-Middle-Income	1%	4%
Low-Income	0%	0%

Table 16. The devolved nations' academic composition by Income Country Category

Devolved Nation	Education	UK sector
England	83%	83%
High-Income Countries	97.5%	90%
LMICs	2.5%	10%
Northern Ireland	2%	2%
High-Income Countries	99.5%	90%
LMICs	0.5%	10%
Scotland	11%	11%
High-Income Countries	94%	89%
LMICs	6%	11%
Wales	4%	5%
High-Income Countries	100%	93%
LMICs	0%	7%

both in Education and UK generally. Of the 45% of UK-based female academics from High-Income countries, 54.5% were employed on senior contracts; while of the male grouping, 62% were in senior contracts. Those employed from Upper-Middle-Income countries, had a lower proportion of females (>42%), of which more were in junior positions (61%) compared to the proportion at that level of their male counterparts (>58%). The <4% of staff employed from Lower-Middle-Income countries again had higher proportions of females at junior positions (68.5%) than their male counterparts (>60%). Of the proportion from Low-income countries (>0%), an even higher proportion of females were in junior roles (73.5%), as were the males employed (59.5%).

Similarly, a study of Swedish universities found those born in Eastern Europe, Asia, Africa, and South America were not only more likely to face barriers to accessing employment, but once employed they were positioned at junior levels (Behtoui and Høyer Leivestad 2019).

At the level of full professor in Education, 97% were recorded as holding primary nationality in High-Income countries, <1% Upper-Middle-Income countries and >1% Middle-Income countries. Similar patterns of narrowing up the ranks towards full professorship, of the representation of racialised minorities, females, and migrant academics were observed in the composition of assigned leadership of deans in Canadian universities (Lavigne 2020).

Discussion about inequalities in the routes to intellectual authority in the UK

In this paper, we have constructed data portraits to explore indications of inequalities in the traditional routes to intellectual authority through academia in the UK. While the administrative data disallow nuanced depictions of the rich heterogeneity of such academics' identities, racialised minorities who have gained access to academic employment in UK universities were found to have more plurality of religious beliefs and nationalities than their 'white' counterparts, and to represent more of the Majority World. This brings undeniable capital to a sector characterised and experienced as elitist, colonial, predominantly 'white', and Western.

However, it is apparent that racialised minorities are under-represented within the UK academic workforce. Despite equality legislation's focus on the UK public, the study revealed that low proportions of racialised minorities with UK nationality had gained access to employment. This confirms concerns that regulation and practice-based initiatives have not been effective in ensuring the pipeline to academic employment for local racialised populations is protected from whiteness, white supremacy, and patriarchy. Inequalities of outcomes in the positioning of racialised minorities on the professional academic hierarchy have maintained structural disadvantage within such traditional routes to intellectual authority. Recruitment at, and attainment of, senior level and particularly positions of the assigned leadership of full 'professor' or 'chair', continued to be problematic. This was despite the time period studied being characterised by consciousness-raising of the sectors' inequalities, and the value of a more pluralistic and global workforce. Setting these patterns against other findings about the research and employment ecology shows further structural disadvantage. For instance, low award rates and low amounts of UK research funding have been particularly acute for 'black' primary investigators (UKRI 2021) and 'ethnic minority' females (UKRI 2024). 'Ethnic minority' pay gaps have been exposed in elite universities ('Russell Group'), and the gender pay gap is more pronounced for racially minoritised women, particularly for 'black' and 'Arab' academics (Croxford 2018). Joining the dots between various forms of marginalisation and injustice is important to comprehend the cumulative impact on the conditions for academic freedom and flourishing, particularly since racialised minorities and women have reported perceiving more threats than their counterparts when exercising their academic freedom in the UK (Blell, Liu, and Verma 2022; Karran and Mallinson 2017).

The study focused on the discipline of Education as a 'case' to comprehend the impact of disciplinary cultures. Its staff composition was found to be considerably more homogenous in terms of 'race', nationality, sex, and religious belief. Findings about staff access, attainment,

and progression indicate that conditions were considerably less favourable for Education's racially minoritised staff. We found that those recorded as 'black' were particularly under-represented in Education. Female staff recorded as 'black' African/descent were barely represented in Education generally and excluded from flourishing at full professor level. The rates of growth were insufficient to address existing inequalities in access. Moreover, the implementation of such growth in junior grades and in 'teaching only' contracts is counterproductive for addressing racial inequalities in the pipeline to assigned leadership for research and institutional decision-making. Given the small proportions of those permitted access from the Majority World, the exclusion of those from Low-Income countries, and unequal proportions of male to female staff from those contexts, there should be particular concern that black females who are Africa-born are excluded from access to, and attainment and progression in, Education. The issue of assigned leadership for Black academics within universities, and their relation to the routes to intellectual authority within the Minority World, suffers from deprioritisation in international agendas.

While group identity, such as 'race', 'sex', or 'nationality', may not be the determining factor in knowledge hegemonies (Krause 2016), the absence of representation is itself an indictment of the state of coloniality of Education. Considering that perceptions of the availability of good-quality employment in the professional context of UK academia were found to play a primary role in migrant academics' decisions to migrate to the United Kingdom (UK) (Pustelnikovaite 2021), it is hoped that the patterns of inequalities in access and participation of migrant academics reported herein, may provide more informed decision-making for those considering such academic migration. Migration is a costly 'brain drain' for the Majority World (Gwaradzimba and Shumba 2010). In light of the exclusions and inequalities found in this study, questions should be raised about the claims of the 'mutual' benefit of academic mobility, international collaboration, and exchange across the Global North-South.

Conclusions on colourising the gaps between rhetoric and reality about representational justice

In this paper, we have colourised the gap between rhetoric and reality by analysing whether the UK's public universities embody principles espoused, in particular representational justice, through critical quantitative analysis of administrative data known about the traditional routes to intellectual authority.

UK universities' role in contributing to the Sustainable Development Agenda is impacted by the discipline of Education, through its education function by current and future educators, and its research function. This study found that the academic composition of those in the discipline of Education significantly over-represented the Minority World, and that geopolitical inequalities in access for those few academics from the Majority World intersected with structures of racialisation and patriarchy. Consistent across the UK were the considerably higher proportions of academic staff recorded as 'white', holding UK primary nationality, and of Christian belief in Education. Despite having a higher proportion of female academics, conditions were particularly dire for female academics from the Majority World. It is particularly of concern that a discipline such as Education has such acute racialised inequalities in the representation of its local populations.

While guarding against methodological nationalism, our study demonstrates the importance of scholars of UK universities accurately representing context(s) studied, particularly when reporting on inequality. In such ways, the paper builds on Shattock and Horvath's (2020) exploration of the relationship between devolution, higher education, and equality; and addresses the shortcomings noticed in a review of the national foci of UK educational research activity (Stentiford et al. 2021). The lack of attention has enabled blindspots to persist, to the detriment of minoritised academic citizens. An example is Northern Ireland, where despite racism and related hate crimes being a known public concern (Gilligan 2019), the responsiveness of universities (Belluigi 2024) and the composition of their academic staff has until only very recently been academically explored, in part due to this study. However, while state pressure to address the complacency and inertia of universities to address racialised and gendered outcomes has been advocated by scholars (Pilkington 2020), the current government in Westminster has reasserted that there are no requirements for going 'beyond what is necessary to comply with their legal duties under the [equality] act' (DSIT 2024, 24). For matters of the public and global common good, the recourse to scholars within universities 'calling out' inequalities is unsustainable and unethical. Whether decision-making powers are centralised or devolved, there should be an expectation of institutional accountability.

The findings of this paper challenge the veracity of the UK's claims of moral authority, egalitarianism, and meritocracy. It is disconcerting that despite the massive machinery of collection, reporting, surveillance, and monitoring that is part of UK governmentality, and the significant critical scholarship from within UK universities, that 'data' remain the most significant limitation of studies on inequality such as these. Such dysconscious data literacy demonstrates the danger of positioning the transformation of universities for social justice (Tibbits and Keet 2023) and race equality (Achieme 2018), as peripheral to the international human rights' agenda, international resolutions, and development frameworks such as the SDGs. The lack of such relation has enabled transparency about racial inequality in these traditional routes to intellectual authority to be obfuscated by systemic shortcomings in the categorisation, collection, and reporting of official data of UK universities, which continues to enable avoidance of sectoral accountability about institutional racism (Andrews 2019) and xenophobia. International attention is required to comprehend the damage to the global common goods and to international sustainable development agendas when racialised, geopolitical, gendered inequalities are reproduced in academic staffing in such influential prior colonies.

Notes

1. Polemic constructions of intellectual authority have been conjured to assert the moral and political influence of 'superior minds over the multitude', as in John Stuart Mill's (1901) colonial liberalism. They are also constructed as a bulwark against the human-driven and algorithmic campaigns in social media, and propaganda by belligerent nations; for which 'critical authority' in public intellectualism is valorised by Johansen (2021). With neoliberalism, such seemingly conflicting discourses can be seen in Moschella's (2020, 86) analysis of the International Monetary Fund's 'technocratic self-image and its ability to establish its intellectual authority'.
2. Routes to intellectual authority are enabled through many social, cultural, and political institutions. Mayers, Thompson, and Cruickshank (2023) use 'infrastructures' of intellectual authority to point beyond these, to the licencing of ideas and

their purveyors as authoritative, in USA–Australian Christian relations during and since the Cold War. They found that the ‘shifting cultural and political landscapes, racial justice, authority of science, and decolonisation have entangled histories’ (Mayers et al. 2023, 511).

3. For more, consider Collier’s (1992) review of empirical and experimental research on the theoretical basis of intellectual authorship, and on the issue of ‘bias’ of institutional authority.
4. <https://datahelpdesk.worldbank.org/knowledgebase/articles/906519>.
5. https://www.zotero.org/groups/4566021/edi_in_uk_he.
6. Source: https://assets.publishing.service.gov.uk/government/uploads/system/uploads/attachment_data/file/1076311/citizenship-datasets-mar-2022.xlsx.

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